

Why the Sacré-Cœur took forty years to build

A national vow, a stubborn hillside, and the slow climb of the basilica that now defines Montmartre's skyline.

Camille Roussel · June 12, 2026 · 9 min read

PHOTO — SACRÉ-CŒUR, FULL-WIDTH HERO

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Long before the white domes appeared on the skyline, the Butte Montmartre was a place of quarries, windmills and a small village that Paris had not yet swallowed whole. What rises there today was never a quick undertaking — it was the result of politics, faith and an engineering problem nobody saw coming.

A hillside with a past

The hill's gypsum quarries had been mined since the Middle Ages, leaving the ground beneath honeycombed with tunnels. It is a detail that will matter enormously once construction begins.

"They were not just building a church. They were trying to anchor a hill that kept threatening to swallow it."

The national vow of 1873

Following the trauma of the Franco-Prussian War and the Paris Commune, a national subscription funded the basilica as an act of penance and hope. Construction began in 1875, financed entirely by public donation rather than the state.

PRACTICAL INFO

HOURS

6:00am – 10:30pm daily

ENTRY

Free · Dome access €7

ADDRESS

35 Rue du Chevalier de la Barre

Building on unstable ground

Engineers discovered the quarry tunnels could not support the structure's weight, forcing them to sink eighty-three pillars up to thirty-three metres deep — nearly as far down as the basilica rises up.

- 1

Climb the dome

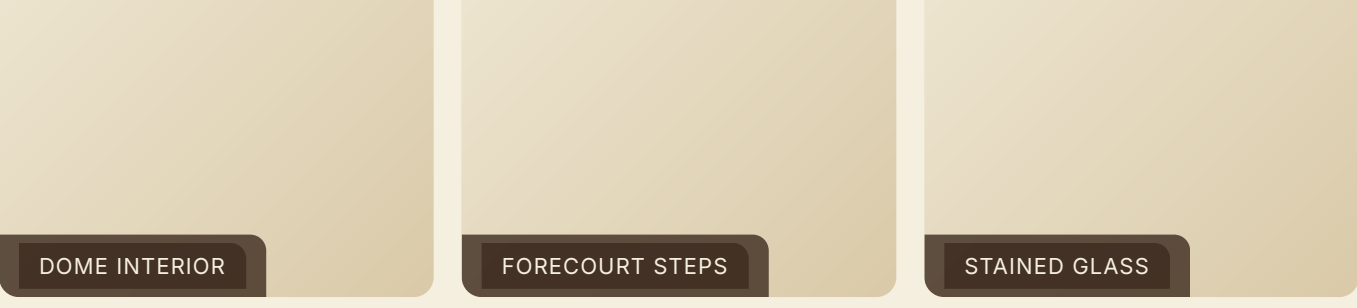
300 steps for the best 360° view of Paris.
- 2

Visit at opening time

The forecourt is nearly empty before 9am.
- 3

Look for the mosaic

One of the largest in France, inside the apse.



The basilica today

Completed in 1914 and consecrated after the First World War, the Sacré-Cœur has been in continuous prayer since 1885 — a detail most visitors photographing the view never learn.

Camille Roussel

Writes about Montmartre's history and the stories behind its landmarks. Based in the 18th arrondissement.

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PLAN YOUR VISIT

One ticket, three ways up the hill